



Why wouldn't everyone prefer to be homeless? It would be a lot simpler and cheaper. Because the comforts of home are missing when a person is homeless most people prefer to have a place they can call their home. God also wants a home, even though He is present everywhere at the same time. Why does God want a home? The reason God wants a home of His own is so that people can draw near to Him. But drawing near to God is not so simple.

Did you know that in the Old Testament that people rarely wanted to draw near to God? Why? Because it meant almost certain death. When Moses asked to see God's face, God told him, "A man shall not see me and live" (Exodus 33:20). After wandering in the wilderness for 40 years, Moses asked the people of Israel, "Did any people ever hear the voice of a god speaking out of the midst of the fire, as you have heard, and still live?" (Deuteronomy 4:33). When the Angel of the Lord appeared to Gideon, Gideon expected to die. The Angel told him, "Peace be to you. Do not fear; you shall not die" (Judges 6:22-23).

In the Bible there are six different temple-like places where believers met with the one true God. The first temple-like place was the Garden of Eden. It functioned as a Temple where God met with Adam and Eve. The second was the Tabernacle that God told Moses to construct according to very specific instructions. The third was the Temple built under King Solomon's authority. The fourth was the Temple built at the time of Ezra

and Nehemiah, called Zerubbabel's Temple because Zerubbabel was the priest who acted as overseer of its construction. Fifth, was the Temple built by King Herod, which Jesus referred to as His Father's house (Luke 2:49; John 2:16). The last Temple is a very different kind of Temple. It began as the physical body of Jesus, while He walked on the earth (John 2:19-22). After Jesus' death and resurrection, believers became part of the body of Christ (1 Corinthians 12:27). As part of the body of Christ they are also becoming part of a new kind of Temple which was first revealed as Jesus' physical human body (Ephesians 2:19-21; 1 Peter 2:4-5; see also Ephesians 4:12 for the connection to the body of Christ with the body of believers).

Last week I spoke about how people returned to Jerusalem after 70 years in bondage. The goal of their return was to rebuild the Temple. We discussed how they settled their families into the land and began to worship God by giving sacrifices, as described in the Law of God. The next phase of building the new Temple was to pay the craftsmen who would make it (Ezra 3:7).

⁷ So they gave money to the masons and the carpenters, and food, drink, and oil to the Sidonians and the Tyrians to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea, to Joppa, according to the grant that they had from Cyrus king of Persia (Ezra 3:7).

As the project proceeded, Zerubbabel and the other Levites were overseers of the building project (Ezra 3:8).

⁸ Now in the second year after their coming to the house of God at Jerusalem, in the second month, Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel and Jeshua the son of Lozada made a beginning, together with the rest of their kinsmen, the priests and the Levites and all who had come to Jerusalem from the captivity. They appointed the Levites, from twenty years old and upward, to supervise the work of the house of the Lord (Ezra 3:8).

When the foundation was completed, a celebration took place which included more sacrifices to God.

¹⁰ And when the builders laid the foundation of the temple of the Lord, the priests in their vestments came forward with trumpets, and the Levites, the sons of Asaph, with cymbals, to praise the Lord, according to the directions of David king of Israel. ¹¹ And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the Lord, "For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel." And all the people shouted with a great shout when they praised the Lord, because the foundation of the house of the Lord was laid (Ezra 3:10-11).

Some people who had seen the Temple built by Solomon were overwhelmed with grief.

¹² But many of the priests and Levites and heads of fathers' houses, old men who had seen the first house, wept with a loud voice when they saw the foundation of this house being laid, though many shouted aloud for joy, ¹³ so that the people could not distinguish the sound of the joyful shout from the sound of the people's weeping, for the people shouted with a great shout, and the sound was heard far away (Ezra 3:12-13).

We might ask, "What was wrong with this new Temple? Why were these people sad?" The people who had seen the earlier Temple, built by Solomon, looked at the completed foundation for the new, incomplete Temple, and were overwhelmed with grief. The people who had never seen the old Temple thought everything looked great, and for them it was time to celebrate. For the old timers, though, it was a time to mourn for what was lost, realizing that the new Temple lacked the glory and splendor of the previous Temple.

There is more to this sense that this new Temple was a cause for sadness. When Moses had first erected the Tabernacle, the glorious presence of God had entered the Tabernacle, and no one could enter it to do anything (Exodus 40:34-35). When the Temple built under Salmon's direction was first completed, the same thing happened. God's glorious presence entered the Temple and none of the priests could go into it because the light was too powerful (2 Chronicles 7:1&2). The funny thing is this never happened with Zerubbabel's Temple. We can read in Ezra 6:15 that the task of building the Temple was completed. We can also read that the people celebrated the completion of the Temple by slaughtering a Passover lamb (Ezra 6:20). Nowhere is there any mention of the presence of God visibly entering the Temple. Does this mean that God didn't dwell in

Zerubbabel's Temple? There is no mention in historical records of God's presence entering Herod's Temple either, but Jesus did not hesitate to call it His Father's house (Luke 2:49; John 2:16). If Herod's Temple was God's House, then Zerubbabel's Temple would have also been God's house. In what sense were those two Temples God's house? Did God's presence really dwell in either Herod's Temple or Zerubbabel's Temple? God's presence never visibly entered either Temple. Yet Jesus did call Herod's Temple His Father's house, showing that the Temples of Herod and Zerubbabel were both recognized by God as genuine places where people rightfully worshipped God and drew near to Him.

What made the people who worshipped in the Temple right with God? Sacrifices offered pleased God because they were offered according to the requirements given in the Law given to Moses. God's anger with the people's sin was set aside because of the sacrifices.

The people who had seen the previous Temple were disappointed because the new Temple was very unimpressive in comparison. However, we have no reason for disappointment concerning the Temple that Jesus is building now. The Temple Jesus is building is a living, breathing, eternal Temple, more glorious than has ever been known in all of history. Those who believe in Him are "living stones", and Jesus is the chief cornerstone, of this new Temple being built right now (1Peter 2:4-5).

⁴ As you come to him, a **living stone rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious**, ⁵ you yourselves like **living stones** are being **built up as a spiritual house**, to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. 1 Peter 2:4-5 (ESV)

Notice that Jesus also was a "living stone." He was "rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious". Those who believe in Jesus are "living stones" being "built up as a spiritual house." The term "spiritual house" is another way of referring to a Temple of the one, true God. This new Temple now under construction is an entirely different kind of Temple than all the Temples that came before it. Why is it so different?

The first way that this new Temple is different is that it began as Jesus' physical body. His body was a Temple because the presence of God was dwelling in His human flesh, drawing near to those who believe in God.

Jesus answered them, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up." John 2:19 (ESV)

²¹ But he was speaking about the temple of his body. ²² When therefore he was raised from the dead, his disciples remembered that he had said this, and they believed the Scripture and the word that Jesus had spoken. John 2:20-22 (ESV)

When Jesus rose again His resurrection body continued to function as a Temple of the one, true, living God. Evidently Jesus explained how this would work when he died and rose again. Jesus accusers took His claim and used it as an accusation against Him.

⁵⁸ "We heard him say, 'I will destroy this temple that is made with hands, and in three days I will build another, not made with hands.' " Mark 14:58 (ESV)

When Jesus rose from the dead His body was a true temple not made with human hands.

Believers are part of the body of Christ (Roman's 12:5; 1 Corinthians 12:27; Ephesians 4:12). Because they are part of the body of Christ believers are currently in the process of becoming part of the new Temple being built.

¹⁹ So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, ²⁰ built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, ²¹ in whom the whole structure, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord. ²² In him you also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit. _ (Eph 2:19-22).

Those who believe in Jesus Christ are living, breathing building blocks of the living breathing Temple where God dwells. When we say that God is within a believer that is only possible because Jesus was the first Temple of this kind, and those who believe in Jesus are being made into the same kind of Temple. This is a very different kind of Temple than the one built of precious stones and gold.

Let's review what we've considered.

Why did God choose to use a Temple as a place where He could meet with believers? God wanted to draw near to the people who believed in Him. The Temple was the only way this could happen without the people dying in the process. First of all, sacrifices had to be given to God according to the instructions of God's Law. When this worked well, believers experienced great joy when they drew close to God their creator, who had called them to Himself.

What happened at the different Temple-like places so that believers could safely draw near to God? Only by offering sacrifices could believers be made right with God. Only after getting right with God could believers draw near to God, and not die. This is made clear by the fact that even the priests could not perform their duties in the Temple until they had made sacrifices for their own sins (Leviticus 4:3). Aaron had to go through this same process of making sacrifices for his own sins before he could perform his priestly duties (Leviticus 9:7).

How is the last Temple-like place very different from all other Temple-like places? One very big difference is that there is only one sacrifice that has been given: Jesus Christ, when He died on the cross (Hebrews 7:27; 9:26). Jesus' sacrifice has made all those who believe in Him right with God (Romans 5:10). Those who believe in Jesus have been forgiven of their sins, so they can enter into the presence of God with confidence ("Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" Hebrews 4:16 NIV). Another very big difference is that the new Temple is built from "living stones" (1 Peter 2:4-5) not non-living stones. The new Temple goes out to the people to draw them nearer to God, by sharing the Gospel with them. With previous Temples people had to go to the Temple, now the Temple goes to them.

What does the last Temple-like place have in common with previous Temple-like places? Believers have been drawn nearer to God by all the different kinds of Temples.

If you're a believer, you are a "living stone" in the Temple of God. You don't have to go anywhere to draw near to God because God is with you everywhere you go. In fact, Jesus said, ¹⁹"Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, ²⁰and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. **And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age.**" Matthew 28:19-20 (NIV). Rejoice that you are living in the presence of God at all times.

Believers are bringing the presence of God with them everywhere they go. If we are honest, we must admit that most of us who believe in Jesus fail to be adequate bearers of the presence of God. We should be pure, so that people will be ready to hear the Gospel message we bring to them. How did Jesus bring this down to earth, in terms that we can understand? He said we should love God with all our heart, soul, and mind; and we should love others as ourselves (Matthew 22:37; Mark 12:30; Luke 10:27). Another way of saying this is that we should love others the same way that Jesus loved us (John 13:34; John 15:12; 2 John 5). There is only one way a believer can love others the way Jesus loved them: surrender to Jesus' and ask Him to take control of our words and actions. Remember what He said, ¹⁹"Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, ²⁰and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age" Matthew 28:19-20 (NIV). We will still fall short of the standard set by Jesus, but by God's grace the presence of Jesus and His great love will flood over any obstacles we put in His way. Jesus will be glorified.

R F D E C R O B E C A U S E
 H O F F E R L H L P S I H Z
 C O M E M I E F P H D S E Z
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When the **seventh month came**, and the children of **Israel** were in the towns, the **people** gathered as one man to **Jerusalem**. Then arose **Jeshua** the son of **Jozadak**, with his fellow **priests**, and **Zerubbabel** the son of **Shealtiel** with his **kinsmen**, and they built the **altar** of the God of **Israel**, to **offer burnt offerings** on it, as it is **written** in the Law of Moses the man of God. They set the **altar** in its place, for fear was on them **because** of the **peoples** of the lands, and they **offered burnt offerings** on it to the **LORD**, **burnt offerings** morning and evening. And they kept the **Feast** of Booths, as it is **written**, and **offered** the daily **burnt offerings** by number **according** to the rule, as each day required, and after that the regular **burnt offerings**, the **offerings** at the new moon and at all the **appointed feasts** of the **LORD**, and the **offerings** of everyone who **made** a freewill **offering** to the **LORD**. From the first day of the **seventh month** they began to **offer burnt offerings** to the **LORD**. But the **foundation** of the temple of the **LORD** was not yet **laid**. So they gave money to the masons and the carpenters, and food, drink, and oil to the Sidonians and the Tyrians to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea, to Joppa, **according** to the grant that they had from Cyrus king of Persia. Now in the second **year** after their **coming** to the **house** of God at **Jerusalem**, in the second **month**, **Zerubbabel** the son of **Shealtiel** and **Jeshua** the son of **Jozadak** **made** a beginning, together with the rest of their **kinsmen**, the **priests** and the **Levites** and all who had **come** to **Jerusalem** from the captivity. They **appointed** the **Levites**, from twenty **years** old and upward, to **supervise** the work of the **house** of the **LORD**. And **Jeshua** with his sons and his brothers, and Kadmiel and his sons, the sons of Judah, together **supervised** the workmen in the **house** of God, along with the sons of Henadad and the **Levites**, their sons and brothers. And **when** the builders **laid** the **foundation** of the temple of the **LORD**, the **priests** in their vestments **came** forward with trumpets, and the **Levites**, the sons of Asaph, with cymbals, to **praise** the **LORD**, **according** to the directions of David king of **Israel**. And they sang responsively, **praising** and giving thanks to the **LORD**, “For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward **Israel**.” And all the **people** **shouted** with a great **shout** **when** they **praised** the **LORD**, **because** the **foundation** of the **house** of the **LORD** was **laid**. But many of the **priests** and **Levites** and heads of fathers’ **houses**, old men who had seen the first **house**, wept with a loud voice **when** they saw the **foundation** of this **house** being **laid**, though many **shouted** aloud for joy, so that the **people** could not distinguish the **sound** of the joyful **shout** from the **sound** of the **people’s** weeping, for the **people** **shouted** with a great **shout**, and the **sound** was heard far away.

(ESV)